

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Blitz may be winding down

Federal Border Patrol chief Gregory Bovino and agents preparing to leave Chicago, sources say

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

After two months of raids that netted thousands of arrests but also sparked outrage and resistance, a surge of federal immigration agents that came to the city as part of the Trump administration's Operation Midway Blitz may soon leave Chicago as the controversial

mission winds down, multiple law enforcement sources told the Tribune.

Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino, the top official on the ground leading the Trump administration's efforts, was expected to depart Chicago for another assignment within days, and most of the agents under this command would soon be redeployed elsewhere,

three sources told the Tribune Monday morning.

An on-call task force composed of FBI and assistant U.S. attorneys is also expected to close up shop in the coming days, two of the sources said.

But the winding down of Operation Midway Blitz, which began in early September, does not mean that enhanced immigration enforcement will end anytime soon. The sources said the feds planned to leave in place a still-to-be-determined force of some

Border Patrol agents as well as extra Enforcement and Removal Operations, or ERO, officers with the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

In a statement Monday, a spokesperson for the Department of Homeland Security, which is overseeing the operation, did not confirm or deny the agency's plans, saying: "every day DHS enforces the laws of this country, including in Chicago. We do not comment or telegraph future operations."

Bovino did not respond to

repeated attempts to contact him Monday and Tuesday. In a statement on X, DHS spokesperson Tricia McLaughlin posted, "We aren't leaving Chicago," but did not directly address the issue of Bovino's departure.

CBS and CNN have both reported that Bovino will head to North Carolina next.

"If the reports are true, it could not have come soon enough," Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Veterans Day salutes

Rogelio Villa salutes during the American Legion Veterans Day ceremony Tuesday at Manuel Perez Jr. Memorial Plaza in Chicago's Little Village neighborhood. Downtown, hundreds gathered to honor veterans and march against the Trump administration. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

ANALYSIS

For Trump, nothing was off-limits

Harsh tactics placed pressure on Democrats to end long shutdown

By Luke Broadwater
The New York Times

WASHINGTON — The government shutdown is already the longest in American history. But it's also perhaps the most punishing — in part because President Donald Trump has taken actions no previous administration ever took during a shutdown.

Over the past six weeks, the Trump administration cut food stamps for millions of low-income Americans. It tried to fire thousands of government workers and withhold back pay from others, while freezing or canceling money for projects in Democratic-led states.

It remains to be seen whether there will be a political price to pay for Trump or his party, with polls showing that voters generally blamed Republicans more for the shutdown. But for now, the tactics appear to have worked, after a small group of Democrats agreed to support a bill to end the shutdown and drop the concessions their party had demanded.

The 60-40 vote Monday night in the Senate ended a grueling stalemate, sending the bill to the House. But the shutdown

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SNAP recipients Elizabeth Avrck, left, and her sister Jennifer Avrck get ready to leave Manny's Deli after eating a free meal at the restaurant on Nov. 4. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

With uncertainty around SNAP, restaurants offering free meals

Aim to help food stamp recipients in time of need

By Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

When Manny's Cafeteria and Delicatessen posted on social media that they'd be handing out free meals to SNAP recipients starting Nov. 1, the line the next day started forming at 3 a.m. The deli doesn't open until 8.

Dan Raskin, owner of Manny's Deli in Chicago's

South Loop neighborhood, said the restaurant initially planned to give away 100 meals a day through Nov. 9, but it quickly jumped to 300 after customers started asking if they could donate to the cause. After Sunday, the deli had to pause to reorder more food, but has plans to unveil larger meal drops at a third-party location in the city.

Disruptions to the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, often referred to as food stamps, during what has become the longest government shutdown in American

history, have left recipients without adequate funds to buy food. The delay has forced millions of families to make do with small collections from food banks or the generosity of restaurants. According to the U.S. Department of Agriculture, nearly 2 million people in Illinois are enrolled in SNAP.

Raskin said that helping those facing disruptions to SNAP was a top priority for the family-run deli. Dozens of restaurants across Chicago seem to share that sentiment

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Mail-in ballot case may impact state's laws

Supreme Court expected to decide if they can be counted after Election Day

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

The U.S. Supreme Court has agreed to hear arguments in a Mississippi case that could have a major effect on Illinois' efforts to promote voting by mail, as the high court is expected to decide whether such ballots, cast and postmarked on or before Election Day in a general election, can be counted afterward.

The combined suit — brought by the Republican National Committee and the Libertarian Party and backed by the conservative law group Judicial Watch — asks the nation's high court to uphold a 5th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals decision that said ballots must be received by Election Day in November in order to be counted.

Under Illinois law, mail-in ballots that are postmarked or certified on or before Election Day can be counted by local election authorities up to 14 days after the election. A 2020 law enacted during the COVID-19 pandemic by Mississippi allowed mail-in ballots to be counted within five business days of Election Day.

The court's decision could have wide-ranging ramifications for Illinois and as many as 27 other states and the District of Columbia, where local and state laws allow post-Election Day ballots to be counted. Illinois filed a brief in support of upholding the existing Mississippi law.

Judicial Watch is also behind a similar effort to curb post-Election Day vote counting in a federal suit filed on behalf of veteran downstate Republican U.S. Rep. Mike Bost of Murphysboro. Federal courts in Chicago rejected the lawsuit, saying Bost lacked standing to file suit. The Supreme Court has heard oral arguments on the standing issue, but has not yet ruled.

The high court's Mississippi decision could come as early as July, only a few months in advance of next year's critical midterm elections, which will decide control of Congress. Democrats have traditionally been better organized in

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INSIDE

Wrongly convicted men to get \$10M

The Cook County Board approves settlements for the men who spent 23 years in prison for a 1994 slaying. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Memorial for crew of Edmund Fitzgerald

A ceremony remembers the wreck of the legendary shipping freighter 50 years later, gales of November included. **Arts & Living**

